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EDITORIAL



Disability theology: a driving force for change?

Disability theology is a recent field in theological enquiry that changes – at times quite radically – the way (Christian) theologians perceive God and the way believers experience faith. But can it also bring about societal change? Can it be like leaven in the construction of God’s Kingdom (Lk 13, 21)? Theology definitely has a role to play in constructing paradigms, identifying processes of accommodation, justifying conflicts, promoting change, detecting languages, and driving understanding – what role might ‘disability theology’ have in this?

In this issue of the *IJSCC* we leave the floor to theologians from a wide variety of backgrounds, engaged in disability theology, who offer their reflections on this subject. As not all readers may be acquainted with this theological discipline we very briefly present the field (1) and the reasons that lead us to the theme of ‘change’ (2) before introducing the articles that compose this issue (3).

(1) What is Disability theology?

Disability theologies – as an independent field in theological research – developed in the United States at the end of the last century in a dynamic intellectual context, fuelled by the rich theological thinking of renowned theologians such as Karl Rahner, Karl Barth, Emmanuel Mounier, Stanley Hauerwas and Jurgen Moltmann. However, the discipline as a dedicated field of research owes its development to a new academic discipline that emerged in the United States in the 1980s: disability studies.

Encouraged by the Disability Rights Movement, and after the ratification of the Americans with Disabilities Act in 1990, American researchers (mainly sociologists) came together to work on disability issues. In the wake of gender studies, women studies or ethnic studies, their research led to the emergence of an autonomous discipline: disability studies. This new discipline aimed to provide space for researchers to reflect on the experiences and knowledge of people with disabilities. The latter were considered experts in certain fields and holders of knowledge that external researchers do not have. Indeed, the experience of social barriers – physical, mental, psychological, or religious – provides people with disabilities with knowledge that has equal value to any so-called *objective data*.

The presence of disability studies at faith-based universities has enabled the development of theological thinking in relation to disability issues. However, theologies of disability are usually not seen to be part of the field of disability studies, but within the field of theological studies – in constant dialogue, of course, with research in disability studies. Theologies of disability – and we emphasise the plural – are quite varied, even if they unanimously postulate that disability is an integral part of what it means to be human, that it is part of ‘normality’. As Josie Byzek, founder of *Faith Groups for Justice*, said in a sermon in 2000: ‘People have disabilities because people are human. Impairment is a natural part of the human state.’¹

And so, ever since the publication of Nancy Eiesland's iconic book *The Disabled God*² theologians of disability have challenged mainstream representations of God, interpretations of Scripture, and what it means to live a dignified life before God. At first, these theologians had focused on issues of accessibility of places of worship and access to the sacraments. Very quickly however, they understood that theological reflection on disability could not be limited to questions of rights and access alone and they began to denounce the theological anthropology of Christian churches. Part of their argument was that the majority of theologians in history were 'able-bodied' and that, therefore, the experience of disability had not been taken into account in the development of doctrine. They revealed how, in biblical hermeneutics for example, the metaphor of blindness only works because people who can see, associate blindness with something negative.³ This injustice has led theologians to interpret Scripture in the light of the experiences of people with disabilities. They affirm that what God reveals to us – about Godself and about us – through disability and vulnerability, is a key to understanding God's mystery.

The continuously growing body of literature on disability and theology fuels the development of the discipline as an independent research field. Courses are now offered at various universities all over the world (including the only online postgraduate diploma programme in theology and disability in Europe, at the University of Aberdeen). At the University of Aberdeen, leading disability-theologian John Swinton, defines disability theology as follows:

"Disability theology is the attempt by disabled and non-disabled Christians to understand and interpret the gospel of Jesus Christ, God, and humanity against the backdrop of the historical and contemporary experiences of people with disabilities. It has come to refer to a variety of perspectives and methods designed to give voice to the rich and diverse theological meanings of the human experience of disability."⁴

This definition shows the rich variety of perspectives, methods, topics, and dialogue partners in this field of theological enquiry. The present issue of this journal reflects some of that richness.

(2) Disability Theology: a Driving Force for Change?

Can disability theology bring about societal and religious change? This is the question we – Léon van Ommen (University of Aberdeen) and Talitha Cooreman-Guittin (UCLille) – wanted to address at the fourth annual conference held by the European Academy of Religion in Münster (Germany) in August 2021. « Religion and Change » was the overarching theme of the conference, so the focus was on how theology and religion can impact the public and intimate life of people, social attitudes, political choices, cultural and economic dimensions all along the history from classical religions to more recent aspects.

¹Josie BYZEK, 'Jesus and the paralytic, the blind and the lame: A Sermon.' in <http://www.raggededgemagazine.com/1100/1100cft1.htm> (accessed 03/03/2022).

²Nancy EIESLAND, *The disabled God: towards a liberatory theology of disability*, Nashville, Abingdon Press, 1994.

³John HULL, M. *In the Beginning There Was Darkness: A Blind Person's Conversations with the Bible*, London, SCM Press, 2001.

⁴John SWINTON, 'Disability Theology,' in: Ian McFarland, David Fergusson, Karen Kilby, and Iain Torrance (eds.), *Cambridge Dictionary of Christian Theology*, London (Cambridge University Press), 2010.

We, both being very much engaged in disability theology, felt that the discipline had an important contribution to make to this topic. Indeed, when disability and other critical perspectives are not considered, questions about the nature of God, church, and humanness are being asked from a narrow ‘ablebodied’ perspective, often implying that impairment and vulnerability are considered ‘abnormal’ and ‘unwanted’. Religious perspectives inform people’s worldviews and determine their attitudes and actions in society. Hence, promoting a more inclusive society where all are welcome regardless of one’s (dis)abilities may need the transformation of religious beliefs concerning disability.

With these intuitions, we composed an interdisciplinary and international panel seeking to question how critical reflection on the practices and holy texts of faith communities from a disability perspective could lead to a more complete comprehension of God and humanity. Can a renewed hermeneutics bring about changes in the practices of faith communities, e.g. in their liturgical celebrations, in the way people bear witness to their faith, or build community? Can a theological perspective on disability be a driving force in the transformation of our societies towards more inclusiveness and belonging? In this special issue of the *Journal for the Study of the Christian Church*, the contributors seek to address the topic of change along the lines of the above questions, from a Christian disability perspective.

(3) This issue of the IJSCC

The first three articles of this issue have an explicit practical angle, whereas the emphasis in the three last articles is on conceptual input.

In the first article, Hans Schaeffer and Koos Tamminga (the Netherlands) reflect on how academic theology contributes to practicing inclusion as taking part in God’s salvific actions. Building on the conviction that change towards a more inclusive way of living together is brought about by participating in *practices*, the authors state that these practices must be accompanied by theological reflection – and more precisely what they call: ‘corporate theological reflection’. This is the condition for people to become transformed by means of practice.

In the second article Cynthia Tam (Canada) explores how biblical teaching can be lived out with people with profound autism by engaging David Fitch’s idea of faithful presence with the lived experiences of autism. While acknowledging the power differential that exists in a giver-receiver relationship, the author suggests ways to submit to one another mutually and equally, receiving each other as gifts of God, regardless of a person’s abilities. Based on the observation that Church congregations fail to recognise people with profound autism as persons, but rather treat them as projects, the author aptly notes that church members will not have the opportunities to engage with individuals with profound autism deeply enough to welcome them in as family members in the household of God. She convincingly argues for a transformation process that begins with the willingness to intentionally engage people with profound autism, recognising them as siblings gifted by God and valuable parts of the body of Christ.

Axel Liégeois (Belgium), in his article, reflects on the appropriateness of the catholic Church’s sexual morality in the specific context of people with intellectual disabilities. The author observes a real discrepancy between traditional Church morality and prevailing contemporary morality on these issues. The author suggests an open and

respectful attitude towards the sexual needs and experiences of persons with intellectual disabilities. By developing an ethical dynamic of safeguarding minimum boundaries and fostering responsibility in dialogue, he develops eight criteria of responsibility as a moral compass to assess sexual behaviour.

Justin Glyn (Australia) takes up the idea in disability theology that God is disabled, as famously argued for by Nancy Eiesland. Glyn points out that the disabled God is usually conceptualised in relation to the wounds of Jesus, acquired on the cross and still present in the resurrection. However, this narrow conceptualisation misses the point that all of human life is limited, and therefore limitation, rather than an idealised able body, was part of Jesus existence from the very start of his life. Thus, Glyn reappropriates the doctrine of the incarnation through the lens of disability. In this way, Glyn helps to think of disability as inherent part of life rather than as flawed humanity, moving away from discussing disability in terms of theodicy.

Anne Masters (United States of America) discusses the critique on a charity model of disability. This model can be patronising, and has often been replaced by a disability rights model. Neither model is perfect, Masters demonstrates. The continuous and constant transgression of disability rights is a point in case. Despite all good intentions in church and society, Masters explains that there is a 'shadow-narrative' that eclipses the light of the gospel. In her article, Masters looks again at the Scriptural texts that underpin charity. Rather than disregarding the charity model altogether, or the rights model, she argues that we need both rights *and* charity.

Brian Brock (Scotland) further analyses the rights discourse in contemporary society, by focusing on the concept of 'ableism.' Brock is critical of public discourse that puts different '-isms' on a par. By exploring the differences in the fight for justice for people of colour and learning impaired people, he demonstrates that each discourse requires different acts and sociocultural analyses. At the root of the argument is a distinction between justice as actual enactment and procedural visions of justice. Thus, the article highlights the need to critically review the use of 'ableism' in disability theology, and to be aware of the underlying dynamics at play in contemporary discourses of justice.

Finally, this Special Issue concludes with invited reviews of relevant books in the field.

We wish to thank all panellists at the conference and especially those who have offered to rework their contributions as articles for this journal. We would like to express our gratitude to the editors of this journal for trusting us to use this journal as a platform for, what we think, is an important issue for the church to think about.

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